1,000 users at launch with fewer AI features

KenganSocial · 26 October 2026 · from `scripts/capacity-model.mjs` (prices and limits from `scripts/pricing-model.mjs`). Re-run `node scripts/build-launch-ai-doc.mjs` after changes.

> **Recommendation: launch with the core AI plus cloud transcription**
> (`LAUNCH_AI_FEATURES=cloudTranscription` , also the default when the setting is left out). For 1,000 users at typical use this cuts AI API spend from **R21 004** to **R14 141** a month (33% less), keeps clips arriving in about 6 min, and needs no extra servers. Switching cloud transcription off too saves a further R6 732 but makes long-video clips take ~37 min at the busiest hour and needs 10 clip servers instead of 3.

1. The 1,000 users

Plan	Users	Price
Free	500	Free
Creator Starter	250	R299
Creator Pro	150	R699
Agency	80	R3 499
Enterprise	20	R8 999

"Typical use" = customers use 35% of their allowances; "full use" = 100% of every allowance (the worst case). Busiest hour = 2× the average working-hour load.

2. AI modes compared (realistic mix, per month)

Mode	Use	AI API spend	All costs	Profit	Margin	Clip servers at peak	Clips ready in
All AI features on	typical	R21 004	R68 352	R487 735	87.7%	3	6 min
All AI features on	full	R98 702	R180 439	R375 648	67.6%	14	22 min
Launch: core AI only	typical	R7 408	R54 950	R501 137	90.1%	10	37 min
Launch: core AI only	full	R45 934	R146 714	R409 373	73.6%	49	84 min
Launch + cloud transcription	typical	R14 141	R61 489	R494 598	88.9%	3	6 min
Launch + cloud transcription	full	R84 405	R166 142	R389 945	70.1%	14	22 min

Revenue is the same in every mode (R556 087 a month net of VAT): switched-off features have non-AI versions, so plans and prices don't change. "Clips ready in" is processing plus the average wait at the busiest hour.

3. Where the AI money goes (typical use)

Cost line	All AI features on	Launch: core AI only	Launch + cloud transcription
AI credits (AI)	R5 917	R4 057	R4 057
Clip AI (transcript ranking) (AI)	R3 013	R3 013	R3 013
Voice, music, render licence (AI)	R5 342	R338	R338
Post delivery (egress)	R6 466	R6 466	R6 466
Storage (GB-month + download)	R3 756	R3 756	R3 756
Firestore and sync	R2 130	R2 130	R2 130
Cloud transcription (AI)	R6 732	R0	R6 732
Servers (workers, API, web)	R7 700	R7 894	R7 700
Payfast fees	R24 684	R24 684	R24 684
Fixed (licence, backups, domain)	R2 613	R2 613	R2 613
Total	**R68 352**	**R54 950**	**R61 489**

- **AI credits** cost less per credit in launch mode because credits can only buy text (~$0.006 a credit) instead of images, lyrics and website analysis (~$0.009 a credit on average).
- **Voice, music and render licence** drops to the Remotion licence fee alone: no ElevenLabs voice, no Treblo track, no AI storyboard.
- **Clip AI** (ranking moments in the transcript) is the core product and stays the same in every mode.
- **Cloud transcription** is the one optional feature worth keeping: without it, long videos are transcribed on our own servers, which costs little in money but a lot in waiting time at busy hours.

4. Worst case: every customer uses 100% of their allowance

Mode	AI API spend	All costs	Margin	Servers at peak (short jobs + clips)	Clips ready in
All AI features on	R98 702	R180 439	67.6%	27 + 14	22 min
Launch: core AI only	R45 934	R146 714	73.6%	27 + 49	84 min
Launch + cloud transcription	R84 405	R166 142	70.1%	27 + 14	22 min

At 100% use the AI credits line is the same in every mode: a full allowance can be spent on text alone, and each credit is costed at its worst case. The saving then comes from voice, music, storyboards and cloud transcription.

5. Per plan: 1,000 users on one plan (typical use)

Plan	All AI features on AI spend · margin	Launch: core AI only AI spend · margin	Launch + cloud transcription AI spend · margin
Free	R0 · —	R0 · —	R0 · —
Creator Starter	R11 956 · 84.2%	R4 526 · 87.1%	R6 808 · 86.2%
Creator Pro	R30 463 · 86.4%	R11 233 · 89.5%	R21 884 · 87.8%
Agency	R134 458 · 88.1%	R45 918 · 90.1%	R91 562 · 89.5%
Enterprise	R134 458 · 92.8%	R45 918 · 93.5%	R91 562 · 93.3%

6. What is switched off at launch, and what users get instead

Feature	Setting name	Instead
Lyrics: syncing to the vocals and AI song structure	`lyricsAi`	Paste lyrics: built-in timing and structure; Place automatically / Tap along
Paid AI images (carousels, thumbnail backgrounds, AI Writer)	`aiImages`	Free images (Pollinations) and real video frames
AI voiceover in video ads (ElevenLabs)	`voiceover`	Ads with music and sound effects, no voice
AI-composed music (Treblo)	`aiMusic`	Free music library, matched to the mood
Cloud transcription for long clip videos	`cloudTranscription`	Kept ON at launch (see section 3)
Live web search for trending (Perplexity)	`trendingSearch`	Trending from YouTube and TikTok data and cached ideas
AI reply drafts for DMs and lead outreach	`dmDrafts`	Keyword auto-replies; outreach from a template
AI Edit learning a style from a reference	`styleLearning`	Built-in edit presets
AI business profile from a website	`websiteAi`	Colours, fonts, logo and copy still read from the site
AI thumbnail headline ideas	`thumbnailHeadlines`	Headlines built from the clip's own words
AI storyboards for launch and tutorial videos	`storyboardAi`	Storyboards built from the site and its pages

Always on: clip finding, captions, hooks, hashtags and the AI Writer's text. Turn a feature back on by adding its name to `LAUNCH_AI_FEATURES` in `server/.env` (comma-separated, or `all`) and restarting the API; the API logs which optional features are on at start-up. Asking for a feature that is off returns "coming soon" with the non-AI way to do it.

7. Notes

- The plan limits and the 60% margin guarantee (pricing model) are unchanged; switching features off only lowers costs.
- Typical credit costs are estimates from token sizes; the real figures will come from provider dashboards in the first month. Turn features back on one at a time and watch the spend.
- Server numbers come from jobs measured on a laptop and converted to e2-standard-4 workers; time a few real jobs on the VM to confirm.